Experts Push the Government to Finally Define 'Ultraprocessed' Food

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What exactly makes a food "**ultraprocessed**"? Surprisingly, the U.S. government has never officially said. Now more than 100 science, medical and nutrition experts want that to change.

On Friday, the experts signed an **open letter** to the Office of Management and Budget urging the administration to release the first-ever government definition of **ultraprocessed** foods, often shortened to UPF. "It is critical that **special interests** not hold up this process," the letter read. It noted that most Americans have heard of UPF and wish to avoid them, but few understand them deeply, so guidance is needed.

The push has been building for a while. The administration first announced its effort to define **ultraprocessed** foods in July 2025, and in August the Department of Health and Human Services and the U.S. Department of Agriculture submitted a proposed definition for final review. The foods in question range from sugary cereals and sodas to burgers and store-bought breads. According to media reports, food company CEOs intervened in the definition's release.

So what is **ultraprocessed** food? The term comes from the NOVA system, proposed in 2009 by researchers in Brazil, which sorts foods into four levels based on how much industrial processing they undergo. **Ultraprocessed** foods have been through "extensive industrial manipulation," explained Lindsey Smith Taillie, a nutrition professor at the University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill, who signed the letter. They are broken down and reassembled with cosmetic **additives** such as added colors, flavors and **emulsifiers**.

Studies have linked eating lots of these foods often sugary, salty and fatty to health problems including **cardiovascular disease**, obesity and Type 2 diabetes. Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has connected Americans' overconsumption of them to childhood obesity. The public comment period on the government's definition effort ended on Friday.

Word Treasure

ultraprocessed -- Describes food that factories have changed a great deal, breaking it down and rebuilding it with added colors, flavors and other additives.

open letter -- A letter that is published publicly, often signed by many people, to put pressure on officials to act.

special interests -- Groups that push for rules or decisions that benefit themselves, such as companies in one industry.

additives -- Extra substances put into food to change its color, flavor or texture, or to help it last longer.

emulsifiers -- Additives that help ingredients such as oil and water stay mixed together in a food.

cardiovascular disease -- Diseases that affect the heart and the blood vessels that carry blood around the body.

Background you need

Governments publish official definitions and guidance so that food labels, school meals and health advice all rest on the same shared meaning.

The NOVA system, created by researchers in Brazil, sorts foods into four levels according to how much industrial processing they have been through, and ultraprocessed foods sit at the most heavily processed end.

An open letter is a public appeal that experts sign together to put pressure on officials to act.

Until the government releases its own definition, the word ultraprocessed stays fuzzy, and people cannot be sure which foods it really covers.

Break it down

LEAD: More than 100 experts want the U.S. government to release its first official definition of ultraprocessed foods

KEY EVENT: The experts signed an open letter to the Office of Management and Budget

+- WHO: Science, medical and nutrition experts

+- WHEN: The letter was signed on Friday, the day the public comment period ended

BACKGROUND: The administration announced the definition effort in July 2025, and health and agriculture departments submitted a proposed definition in August

EVIDENCE: Studies link eating lots of ultraprocessed foods to cardiovascular disease, obesity and Type 2 diabetes

OPEN QUESTION: When will the government release the definition, and which foods will it cover?

Why it matters

An official definition could shape food labels, school meals and health advice for millions of families. It would help people understand what they are eating and judge which foods are heavily processed.

Test what you remember

1. What did more than 100 experts do on Friday?

(A) Announced new rules for school lunches
(B) Signed an open letter urging the government to release a definition of ultraprocessed foods
(C) Asked food companies to change their recipes
(D) Published a new system for sorting foods into four levels

2. Which office did the experts send their letter to?

(A) The Department of Agriculture
(B) The University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill
(C) The Office of Management and Budget
(D) The Department of Health and Human Services

3. Where does the term ultraprocessed come from?

(A) A label invented by food companies
(B) A U.S. government rule written in 2025
(C) The NOVA system, proposed by researchers in Brazil
(D) A study of childhood obesity

4. How does the NOVA system sort foods?

(A) By how sweet they taste
(B) By the country they come from
(C) By their price
(D) By how much industrial processing they undergo

5. According to media reports, what slowed the release of the definition?

(A) Experts disagreed about the NOVA system
(B) The open letter was delayed
(C) Food company CEOs intervened
(D) The public comment period was extended

6. Which health problems have studies linked to eating lots of ultraprocessed foods?

(A) Broken bones and allergies
(B) Cardiovascular disease, obesity and Type 2 diabetes
(C) Vision problems
(D) Colds and headaches

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The experts who signed the open letter: They say most Americans have heard of ultraprocessed foods and wish to avoid them but few understand them deeply, so official guidance is needed, and special interests should not hold up the process.

2. Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.: He has connected Americans' overconsumption of ultraprocessed foods to childhood obesity.

3. Food company CEOs: According to media reports, food company CEOs intervened in the release of the government's definition.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):